

ONWARDS BJP's Chandrasekhar leads the party's 'Vikasita Ananthapuri' rally in Thiruvananthapuram, Nov. 5

KERALA

SAFFRON COATING RUNS A LITTLE THIN

It's promising a 'political coup' in the upcoming local body polls tally, but of late the BJP has hit a few speed bumps

out the big guns, especially in the capital. 'VIP candidates' for the Thiruvananthapuram Municipal Corporation include ex-DGP R. Sreelekha and Arjuna Award winner Padmini Thomas.

Since the 2024 general election, where the BJP took 19.2 per cent of the total vote and also won its first Lok Sabha seat from the state, Thrissur, the party has been on a high. "We have fielded the best leaders, people who know the political pulse. Both the LDF and UDF are going to get a shock treatment," says state secretary V.V. Rajesh, who is contesting from Kodungannur ward in Thiruvananthapuram, seen as a party stronghold.

BJP sources say they are eyeing wins in the Thiruvananthapuram and Thrissur Municipal Corporations and retaining the Palakkad and Pandalam municipalities from last time around. Ex-state president K. Surendran is aiming even higher. "We are planning a political coup in Kerala, we'll take more than 100 panchayats, 10 municipalities and two municipal corporations," he told INDIA TODAY.

Takeaways

- **State BJP is on a high after Bihar win, all revved up for the local body elections**
- **A rash of suicides by party members in Thiruvananthapuram has raised a stink**

PITFALLS AHEAD

Two months back, few would have questioned those claims. But the past few weeks, the BJP has been fire-fighting one scandal after another—including a string of party-related suicides in the capital. It started on September 20 with veteran leader and Thirumala ward councillor K. Anil Kumar hanging himself, leaving behind a suicide note accusing BJP leaders of not repaying loans taken from a cooperative society he headed. Next came young tech professional and party worker Ananthu Aji, whose October 6 suicide note had even more damning allegations—that he had been sexually abused by a number of RSS leaders at camps held by the Sangh.

On November 15 came another suicide shocker—local businessman and long-time RSS worker Anand K. Thampi hanging himself after allegedly being denied a ticket in BJP stronghold Thrikkannapuram. More bad news came the next day with BJP Mahila Morcha leader Shalini Anil attempting suicide. The 32-year-old had begun campaigning as a BJP candidate, but was later dropped from the final list. "I was humiliated and couldn't bear it after the local RSS leaders started a character assassination campaign against me," says a tearful Shalini. Later, in a damage control exercise, she was given a ticket from the Neyyattinkara municipality.

The clutch of embarrassments in the capital has put the state unit on the defensive. News filtering in from Palakkad and Pandalam hasn't improved matters. There were unruly scenes after the candidate list was released in the former, while the forward caste grouping, the Nair Service Society (NSS), isn't supporting BJP candidates anymore in the latter. Don't look now, but if the party position dips after the LSG poll, Chandrasekhar may find there is little place to hide with the final, the Kerala assembly election, just months away. ■